

Proposal Title: Zone In! Transforming Digital Spaces into Student Adventures



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PROPOSAL PREVIEW

Zone In! Transforming Digital Spaces into Student Adventures

Proposal ID: 2452231

Session Type: **Workshop**

Event Consideration: **Ignite October 2026 ONLY**

Proposal Status: **Active**

Abstract Submission Details

Topic

1st choice: Teaching and Learning Strategies

2nd choice: AI and Emerging Technology

Alternative Session Type

- Contributed Talk (20 minutes/1 segment)
- Explore and Engage (50 minutes/2 segments)

Audience Classification

- Online Learning

Grade Level Focus

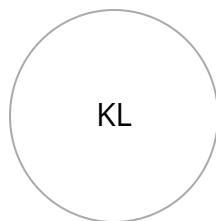
- Elementary Schools
- Middle Schools
- High Schools
- Higher Education (Note: Our audience is focused on K-12. Higher Education attendees tend to be from Colleges of Education or Researchers in the field.)

Abstract Description

What happens when learners stop consuming content and start experiencing it? In this interactive session, participants will explore a mission-based digital learning environment that transforms passive learning into active discovery, collaboration, and problem-solving. Rather than simply discussing immersive learning, attendees will experience it firsthand while navigating challenges inspired by ELA, science, mathematics, social studies, the arts, and career-focused learning.

Throughout the experience, presenters will reveal the design principles and practical strategies behind creating immersive learning opportunities across content areas. Participants will leave with a replicable framework, practical tools, and actionable ideas for designing immersive learning experiences that increase engagement, foster critical thinking, and bring learning to life because learning should be experienced.

Presenter(s)



Kimberly Lunsford (she/her/hers)

Position:

Middle School Teacher

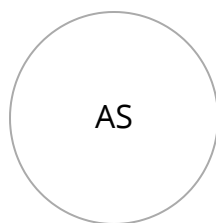
Organization:

Ohio Virtual Academy

Role:

Presenter

Are you a member of DLAC?



Allison Snyder (she/her/hers)

Position:

Teacher

Organization:

Ohio Virtual Academy

Role:

Co-Presenter

Speaker Biography

Allison Snyder is an Intervention Specialist at Ohio Virtual Academy who believes learning should be experienced, not simply completed. Working primarily with students receiving specialized instruction, she is passionate about creating engaging and accessible learning opportunities that meet students where they are while encouraging exploration, creativity, and growth. Allison enjoys designing immersive digital experiences, reimagining assessment, and finding innovative ways to increase student engagement in virtual settings. Her work focuses on helping students become active participants in their learning through inquiry, collaboration, and meaningful real-world connections.

Have you presented at a previous DLAC event?

No

Are you a member of DLAC?

No

Learning Objectives

1. At the end of this session, participants will be able to analyze the key components of an immersive digital learning experience and their impact on student engagement and learning
2. At the end of this session, participants will be able to develop a plan for implementing an interactive, mission-based learning experience within their own grade level or content area.

Additional Information (Longer, Interactive Session Types)

If you were invited to submit this proposal, please enter your invitation code.

Who is the primary intended audience for your session?

District Leader (Superintendent, Director of Innovation, Technology, etc.)

K–12 Teacher (online, hybrid, or blended)

IT or Technology Support Staff

Professional Development or Training Lead

Researcher or Higher Education Faculty

School Leader (Principal, Site Coordinator, Program Manager)

Special Education or Student Services Staff

Audience Expertise

All Levels - This session is intentionally designed to engage and provide value across experience levels—from beginners to seasoned leaders. (Please only select if your content explicitly supports all levels.)

If you selected Cutting Edge, what truly forward-thinking ideas, tools, or approaches will your session introduce? Share what's new, different, or experimental—and how it could impact the future of digital learning. Please avoid general descriptions like "using tech to engage students" or "new strategies" unless they involve tools, practices, or policies that are not yet widely adopted. (Max 350 characters)

This session explores immersive learning ecosystems that turn digital platforms into interactive adventure spaces while also rethinking how student mastery is assessed. By integrating virtual world design, gamification, interdisciplinary inquiry, and learner agency, participants will examine a scalable model that shifts education away from traditional content delivery and static testing toward experience-driven learning. Within these environments, instruction and assessment are embedded into a shared digital world where students demonstrate understanding through exploration, collaboration, problem-solving, and inquiry. Rather than completing isolated tasks or standardized assessments, learners progress by engaging with challenges that mirror real-world complexity and require them to apply knowledge in authentic contexts. Participants will see how virtual environments can support both teaching and assessment simultaneously, creating opportunities for deeper engagement, sustained curiosity, and meaningful demonstration of understanding. The session highlights practical approaches for designing these systems so they are not just engaging experiences, but sustainable frameworks that can be adapted across a variety of educational settings.

Does your session introduce or feature a specific product, service, or solution (either your own or another organization's)?

Yes – Created by another organization – The session focuses on how our school, district, or team uses a product or service created by a separate organization (e.g., a vendor or partner).

If yes, briefly describe the product/service and how it will be presented in the session. (Max 350 characters)

Topia is a browser-based spatial environment platform that allows users to create and navigate customizable 2D/3D “worlds” where interaction happens through movement and proximity-based video, audio, and embedded media. It supports collaborative spaces for learning, events, and community experiences without requiring downloads, and in this session it is used as the demonstration environment for exploring immersive, spatially designed learning activities.

List 5 keywords or phrases someone might search for to find your session. (Separate each with a comma.)

immersive learning ecosystems, authentic assessments, spatial learning environments, future-ready classrooms, online engagement through collaboration

Describe any interactive elements or audience engagement strategies you plan to incorporate into your session. How will you ensure active participation and engagement from attendees throughout your session?

Attendees will participate in a virtual interactive scavenger hunt inside an immersive environment built in Topia, navigating a spatial learning world to uncover prompts, complete short challenges, and experience how learning and assessment can be embedded into interactive design.

Engagement will follow short cycles of facilitation, hands-on exploration, and reflection. Participants will make choices as they move through the scavenger hunt, collaborate with peers to solve prompts, and share quick takeaways about how the experience could translate to their own instructional settings.

What practical strategies, insights, or tools will attendees gain from participating in your session?

Attendees will gain practical strategies for designing immersive, experience-based learning using spatial environments like Topia, including how to structure lessons as interactive pathways, embed formative assessment into movement and choice-based tasks, and design collaborative challenges that promote deeper engagement. They will also leave with a clear model for turning standards or learning objectives into scavenger-hunt-style experiences that blend exploration, inquiry, and assessment in one cohesive design.

What makes you excited to speak at DLAC Ignite, and what unique perspective or experience will you bring to your session?

We are excited about this session because it challenges the idea that online learning must be passive. Creating immersive digital experiences has allowed my students to become explorers, problem-solvers, and active participants in their learning. We look forward to sharing strategies that help educators transform lessons and assessments into meaningful adventures that foster engagement, curiosity, and authentic learning.

Out of curiosity (this won't affect your proposal): About what percentage of this proposal was written with help from an AI tool?

41–60% – I co-wrote it with AI.

Additional information for reviewers to take into consideration (will not be published anywhere).

This proposal emerged from an organic professional connection within a district-supported professional development session hosted in Topia. During the session, I noticed a teacher sharing that she had not yet begun using the platform to create a learning “Zone” for her students. I offered brief encouragement and extended support if helpful. Shortly after, I was contacted directly by Topia to discuss our district’s K12Zones work and the immersive learning spaces my co-presenter, Allison Snyder, and I had developed.

That initial conversation led to a deeper exchange about how we were using spatial digital environments for instruction and student engagement. Several months later, Topia reached out again to invite us to share our practices more broadly with other educators. This presentation is the result of that invitation and reflects our practical, classroom-based experience using immersive environments to support teaching and learning.